This rustic, Mediterranean-style fish soup—robustly flavored with brandy, orange, and fennel—is simple to prepare and sure to please.

fish soup with fennel

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 1 HR **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

2 tbsp butter
3 tbsp olive oil
1 large fennel bulb, finely chopped
2 garlic cloves, crushed
1 small leek, sliced
4 ripe plum tomatoes, chopped
3 tbsp brandy
¼ tsp saffron threads, infused in a little hot water
zest of ½ orange
1 bay leaf
1¾ quarts (1¾ liters) fish stock
10oz (300g) potatoes, diced and parboiled for 5 minutes
4 tbsp dry white wine
1lb 2oz (500g) fresh black mussels, scrubbed and debearded
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1lb 2oz (500g) monkfish or other firm white fish, cut into bite-sized pieces
6 raw whole tiger prawns
parsley, chopped, to garnish

1 Heat the butter with 2 tbsp of the oil in a large, deep pan. Stir in the fennel, garlic, and leek, and cook over medium heat, stirring occasionally, for 5 minutes, or until softened and lightly browned.

2 Stir in the tomatoes, add the brandy, and boil rapidly for 2 minutes, or until the juices are reduced slightly. Stir in the saffron, orange zest, bay leaf, fish stock, and potatoes. Bring to a boil, then reduce the heat and skim off any foam from the surface. Cover and simmer for 20 minutes, or until the potatoes are tender. Remove the bay leaf.

3 Meanwhile, heat the remaining oil with the wine in a large, deep pan until boiling. Add the mussels, cover, and continue on high heat for 2–3 minutes, shaking the pan often. Discard any mussels that do not open. Strain, reserving the liquid, and set the mussels aside. Add the liquid to the soup and season to taste. Bring to a boil, add the monkfish and prawns, then reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 5 minutes, or until the fish is just cooked and the prawns are pink. Add the mussels to the pan and bring almost to a boil. Serve the soup sprinkled with chopped parsley.